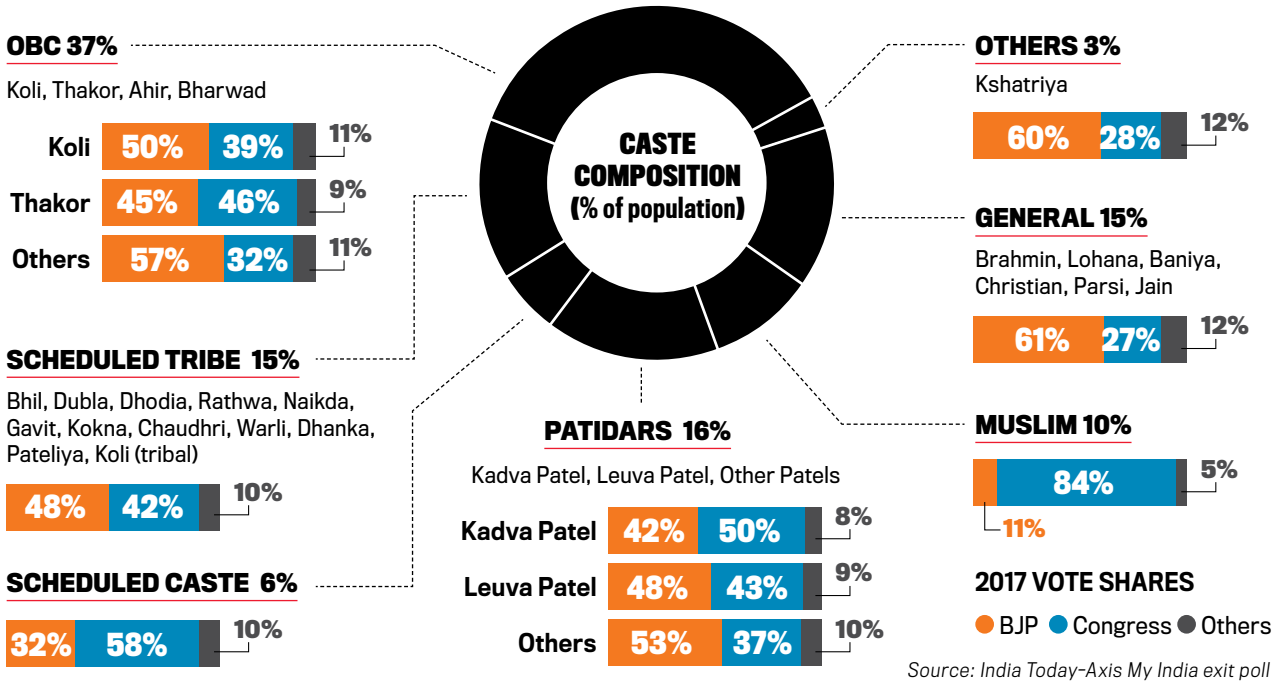
CASTE CALCULATION



Source: India Today-Axis My India exit poll

ers have started complaining as we had to hike the fare for shared rickshaws from Rs 15 to Rs 25," says Shailesh Prajapati, an autorickshaw driver.

Many in the BJP believe that Saurashtra-Kutch is the party's Achilles' heel. In 2017, the Patidar agitation damaged its prospects in this region, where it won just 23 of 54 seats. With Leuva Patels in a majority here, the BJP is trying to induct influential community leader Naresh Patel to woo them. "His clout will remain until the polls at least," says a BJP leader. "Even if people later start looking at him as a politician and not a social worker, he would have served our purpose." The BJP might offer him the post of deputy CM.

Interestingly, leaders who broke away from the BJP ended up helping the party's cause in three successive elections—2007, 2012 and 2017—by ensuring anti-BJP votes didn't go to its main rival. In 2007, Gordhan Zadafia, a minister in then CM Modi's cabinet, got most of the anti-BJP votes for his Gujarat Parivartan Party (GPP) instead of the Congress getting them. Former CMs Keshubhai Patel (GPP) and Shankersinh Vaghela (Jan Vikalp Morcha) did the trick for the BJP in 2012 and 2017, respectively. In 2017, NOTA votes exceeded the winning margin in some seats. Had the 551,615 NOTA voters pressed the button for the Congress instead, the BJP would have been sitting in the Opposition.

THE CONGRESS OFFENSIVE

The mood at Rajiv Gandhi Bhavan, the Congress headquarters in Ahmedabad, was upbeat on April 6. Party workers looked happy after returning from Sabarmati Ashram, where they had launched the 'Azadi Gaurav Yatra'. Aimed at mobilising Congress workers of Gujarat and Rajasthan, the *yatra* will cover four districts of north Gujarat—Ahmedabad, Gandhinagar, Mehsana and Banaskantha—before turning towards Delhi, where it will culminate on June 2.

The *yatra* was initiated after the state Congress appointed 76 general secretaries, the highest number so far, to take on the BJP. But even as the workers reached the party office on April 6, news filtered in that around 400 Congress workers from Banaskantha had joined the BJP earlier in the day. "The BJP is poaching Congress workers because, contrary to the perception, that it is inactive, our party is alive in the state. We have a team. There is strong anti-incumbency and the government is corrupt," claims Manish Doshi, chief spokesperson of the Congress.

While addressing party workers



NANDAN DAVE

IN DEMAND
Both BJP and Congress are trying to induct Naresh Patel, a Leuva Patel community leader